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Esther 1:1–9

Esther

Esther 1:1–9

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Esther 1:1—9 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:1—9 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:1—9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

[The book of Esther is a story about events that happened 60 to 70 years after the first Jews went back to Jerusalem after the exile. The Jews in Jerusalem had completed rebuilding the temple about 40 years before this story. This story happens around 30 years before Ezra, and then Nehemiah, returned to Jerusalem, and around 500 years before Jesus lived on earth. During this story, many Jews still live in Persia, far from Jerusalem. Many of these Jews have settled in Persia and do not return to Jerusalem.]{.mark}

The story begins at the time of a king called “Ahasuerus.” People also call this king “Xerxes.” These are two names for the same king. King Xerxes is a powerful king of Persia who rules over a very large kingdom. King Xerxes’ kingdom reaches from India to Cush in northern Africa. The king divides the kingdom into 127 smaller parts, which he calls provinces, and each province has its own leaders who obey the king.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that shows Persia and the stronghold of Susa. Talk about how large King Xerxes’s kingdom is. Pause this audio here.

King Xerxes sits on his royal throne in the city of Susa, the capital city of Persia. Susa has a stronghold. A stronghold is a strong, raised place that people build to keep the king safe. A stronghold is on high ground above the city. From this place, people can see the whole city below. The king’s palace is inside this stronghold.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of what the stronghold of Susa may have looked like. Pause this audio here.

At around 483 B.C., in the third year that Xerxes is king, Xerxes gives a great banquet for his officials and servants. A banquet is a large meal with many people who eat and drink together for a special reason. King Xerxes invites the governors of Persia and Media. The Persians and the Medes are two groups of people in the king’s kingdom. King Xerxes rules over both groups. King Xerxes also invites military leaders and important men from each province.

During this banquet, King Xerxes shows his great wealth and the riches and beauty of Xerxes’ kingdom. Xerxes continues the banquet for 180 days. In that culture, a king often shows wealth and power in public ways because the king wants people to see his greatness and honor the king.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: In your culture, how do leaders show they are wealthy and powerful? When a leader does this, what might people in the community think or say? Pause this audio here.

Esther 1:1–9

After this banquet ends, King Xerxes gives another banquet. This banquet is for all the people in the city of Susa. King Xerxes invites both important people and less important people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Who might attend a large banquet in your culture? What happens if both important people and common people come together? Pause this audio here.

This banquet lasts for seven days. The king does this banquet in a courtyard near the king's palace. A courtyard is an open space with no roof and a stone floor. Gardens with trees and plants are around this space. These gardens are for beauty, not for farming. A strong wall surrounds the whole area. The palace near the courtyard here may be an open building with a roof and columns, but no walls.

The garden has white and blue cloth, perhaps to shade the guests from the sun. Servants tie the cloth with cords of fine linen and purple cloth. Purple cloth is very expensive, so it shows that the king is wealthy and important. The garden has silver rings and marble pillars. Servants use the rings to tie back the cloth with cords of fine linen and purple cloth. Workers made the couches from gold and silver. People lie on these couches as they eat their food at low tables. The floor has marble and other valuable stones like porphyry and mother-of-pearl. Porphyry is a hard, red or purple stone, and mother-of-pearl is the shiny white part inside a shell. Workers place these stones in patterns to make the floor look beautiful. People call this kind of floor a mosaic. All these things show how rich and powerful the king is.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a mosaic floor. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what things show that a person is rich or important? What special materials or colors show that someone is important or wealthy? Pause this audio here.

Servants give drinks to the guests in golden goblets, or special cups. Each cup is different. The king offers his guests plenty of wine, a drink that people make from grapes. Royal wine means wine that belongs to the king. The king tells the servants to give each person as much as that person wants. In that culture, a king can show kindness and generosity by giving much food and drink.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of some different golden goblets. Talk about what you see. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what does it show when a person gives a lot of food or drink? How do people show that they are generous in your culture?Pause this audio here.

At other times, the king may set rules for how much people should drink. But at this banquet, the king chooses not to use these rules. Instead, the king tells his servants to give each person what that person wants. Each guest can drink as much or as little as that person chooses.

At the same time, Queen Vashti also gives a separate banquet for the women. Queen Vashti holds this banquet elsewhere in the royal palace. The storyteller does not explain why Queen Vashti gives a separate banquet. In Persian royal households, the king often has a harem. A harem is a group of women connected to the king, including wives and concubines. These women often live in a separate part of the palace. Some scholars think that the women at this banquet may come from the royal household, possibly from the harem. But the storyteller does not say this clearly.

This part of the story shows King Xerxes' great power and wealth. The king wants people to see how great Xerxes' kingdom is and to honor Xerxes. In the next part of the story, we will learn what happens when the king gives Queen Vashti a command during the banquet.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:1—9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

Esther 1:1–9

In the first scene: The storyteller introduces the story. The storyteller tells about King Xerxes and when Xerxes rules. The storyteller shows how large the kingdom is and explains that the king rules over many provinces.

In the second scene: King Xerxes gives a great banquet for his officials and leaders. During this banquet, the king shows his great wealth and the riches of his kingdom. The king continues this banquet for 180 days.

In the third scene: After this banquet, King Xerxes gives another banquet. This banquet is for all the people in the city of Susa. The king invites both important people and less important people. This banquet takes place in the courtyard near the palace and lasts for seven days.

In the fourth scene: At the same time, Queen Vashti gives a banquet for the women in another place in the royal palace.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- Officials and governors of Persia and Media
- Military leaders
- Nobles, or important men from the provinces
- Stewards
- People from the city of Susa
- Queen Vashti
- And the women at Queen Vashti's banquet

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The book begins in a way that people often used in that time to tell a true story. The storyteller tells when and where the story happens. The storyteller also introduces important people, including King Xerxes and Queen Vashti. This helps listeners to understand the setting and prepares them for the story. This part of the story also shows that the king is very wealthy and powerful. These ideas will appear again later in the story.

Stop here and discuss as a group: When people tell true stories in your culture, how do those people begin? What information do people give at the start of a story? Pause this audio here.

It is important to remember that King Xerxes rules over a very large kingdom. The king is in the city of Susa at this time, and the king sits on his throne in the city of Susa. When a king sits on his throne, it shows that the king has power and authority.

Susa has a stronghold, a special place where the king lives. Think about how you can show a great king who rules over many lands.

Susa is one of the king's main cities. Susa is lower in the land and warmer, so the king stays there during the colder part of the year. At other times, the king rules from other capital cities.

In the second scene, King Xerxes gathers his governors, officials, military leaders, and nobles, or important men. The king gives a banquet where he offers plenty of food and drink. The king shows his great wealth and the riches of his kingdom. The king continues this banquet over many days, for 180 days. The king wants people to see how great and powerful the king is.

Think about how you can show the king displaying his wealth. You could use simple objects to show valuable things. You could show many people coming to see the king, the king's palace, and what the king owns.

In the third scene, after this long time, King Xerxes gives another banquet. The storyteller uses the phrase "when these days are over" to show that one part of the story has finished and a new part begins.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you show that one part of the story has ended and a new part begins? How will you move from the first banquet to the second banquet? Pause this audio here.

This time, the king invites all the people in the city of Susa. The king invites both important people and less important people. This banquet lasts for seven days. The storyteller says that people come from the greatest to the least. This means people who are both the most important people and people who are the least important people. The phrase "from the greatest to the least" can also mean that all the people in the city come. At that

time, large public banquets like this often included men and women. The storyteller later tells us that Queen Vashti holds a banquet for the women in another place.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you say “from the greatest to the least” in your language? What words will you use to show that all kinds of people are included?

Pause this audio here.

The king holds this banquet in a courtyard near the palace. The courtyard is an open space. Fine cloth hangs around the space, and pillars hold up the cloth. Servants tie the cloth to the pillars with cords and silver rings. We do not know exactly how the cloth hangs in the courtyard, but people attach the cloth to the pillars. People have made this cloth from fine linen and purple cloth. Linen is a strong, smooth cloth that people make from plant fibers. Purple cloth is very expensive and shows wealth. People make couches with frames of gold and silver. People place soft mats or cushions on top of the couches. People lie on these couches as they eat their food at low tables. The floor has many kinds of stone. Workers place the stones in patterns to make the floor look beautiful. People call this kind of floor a mosaic. Think about how you can show this place. You could mark out a large open space. You could place objects to show couches, pillars, and decorations.

Stop here and look as a group at pictures of mosaics, pillars, and couches like these. Talk about what you see. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you describe this courtyard in your language?

What words will you use for the cloth, the pillars, and the couches? How will you show that this place looks rich and beautiful? Pause this audio here.

During this banquet, servants serve drinks in different types of gold goblets or cups.

Stop here and, as a group, look at some pictures of different kinds of gold goblets or cups. Talk about what you see. What words would you use for goblets or drinking cups like these in your language? Pause this audio here.

The king gives much wine to the people. You will remember that wine is a drink that people make from grapes. The king tells the stewards to give each person as much wine as that person wants. A steward is a servant with a more important role than the other servants. This person manages the work in the household and tells the other servants what to do. At other times, the king may make rules for how much people can drink. But in this scene, the king does not use these rules. Each person chooses how much to drink. Think about how you can show the servants serving the people their drinks. Think about how you can show people choosing how much to drink. Notice that the king gives food and drink freely. This shows that the king is very generous and very wealthy.

At the same time, in the fourth scene, Queen Vashti gives a banquet for the women. Queen Vashti holds this banquet in another place in the royal palace. The storyteller does not explain why Queen Vashti gives a separate banquet. Think about how you can show two banquets happening at the same time in different places.

Think about how one part of the story leads to the next part. This story moves from a long display of the king’s wealth to a large banquet for the people and then to two banquets happening at the same time. The king shows his power and wealth to many people. This prepares us for what will happen next in the story.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you learn about King Xerxes from these scenes? What kind of leader does the king seem to be? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:1—9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

Esther 1:1–9

- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- Officials and governors of Persia and Media
- Military leaders
- Nobles, or important men from the provinces
- Stewards
- People from the city of Susa
- Queen Vashti
- And the women at Queen Vashti's banquet

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

King Xerxes rules over a very large kingdom. The king rules over many lands and many people. The king sits on his royal throne in the city of Susa. King Xerxes gathers his governors, officials, military leaders, and important men. The king gives a great banquet. The king shows his wealth and the riches of the king's kingdom for many days.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Xerxes, "What are you feeling or

thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want these people to see how great I am, and I want the people to honor me; or
- I hope these people respect my authority; or
- I feel proud of what I have, and I want to impress these leaders.

Ask the person playing the governors, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am amazed at the king's wealth; or
- I am impressed by what I see around me in the palace; or
- I now realize how powerful King Xerxes is.

Continue the drama.

After this, King Xerxes gives another banquet. The king invites all the people in the city of Susa. Both important people and less important people come. The king holds the banquet in a beautiful courtyard near the palace. Stewards bring food and drinks. The stewards serve drinks in gold cups. The king gives much wine. The king tells the stewards to give each person as much as that person wants.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people from the city, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel so excited that the king invited me to be at this banquet! or
- There is so much food and drink, and the palace is beautiful! or
- I am surprised that I can drink as much as I want or as little as I want.

Ask the person playing the stewards, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have a lot of work to do, and there are so many people to serve; or
- I want to be careful to obey the king; or
- I want to do my work well and please the king.

Continue the drama.

Esther 1:1–9

At other times, the king may set rules for how much people can drink. But at this banquet, the king does not use these rules. Each person chooses how much to drink.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am impressed! The king is so generous; or
- This banquet is different from others; or
- I feel free to choose how much wine I have to drink.

Continue the drama.

At the same time, Queen Vashti gives a banquet for the women. Queen Vashti holds this banquet in another place in the royal palace.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Queen Vashti, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I want to host this banquet well; or
- I want to honor these women; or
- I hope the women are enjoying my banquet.

Ask the person playing the women, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am happy. It is good to be together; or
- The food and drink are delicious! or
- I wonder what is happening at the king’s big banquet.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:1—9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Xerxes rules over 127 provinces. A king is a man who rules a people group or a land. A king gives commands, and people obey the king.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **king**. Look up king in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A province is a smaller part of a large kingdom. The king divides the land into many parts. Each part has leaders who obey the king. The king often divides these areas based on areas where certain groups of people live.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **province**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Xerxes sits on his royal throne in the city of Susa. A throne is a special seat for a king or ruler. The king sits on this seat when he rules or gives commands. This seat shows the king’s power and authority.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for royal **throne**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The city of Susa has a kind of strong place where the king lives. In this story, the stronghold is a protected, raised place inside the city. People build it on high ground so that guards can see far and watch for danger. This also makes it harder for enemies to reach it. Strong walls surround it. The king’s palace and other important buildings are inside this place.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of what the stronghold in Susa may have looked like. Pause this audio here.

Esther 1:1–9

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for this kind of **stronghold**. Look up stronghold in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in this way in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In this story, King Xerxes gives large banquets, or feasts, for many people. A banquet is a large meal with many people. People eat and drink together for a special reason.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **banquet**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The story names several different kinds of leaders in the king's kingdom. All these different leaders come to the king's banquet. Governors are rulers over people groups in the kingdom. Governors lead parts of the kingdom and report to the king. People sometimes call governors "princes" because the governors rule in this way, but governors are not the sons of a king. Military leaders lead the army. Military leaders command soldiers and help protect the kingdom. Officials are people who work for the king in important roles, and sometimes people call officials "servants." Officials do work like managing the kingdom and carrying out the king's commands. Nobles are important men in the kingdom. Nobles often have power and influence in the regions where they live.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **governors**, **military leaders**, **officials**, and **nobles**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Xerxes shows the wealth of his kingdom during the banquet. A kingdom is a land and the people in that land that a king rules. The king has authority over this land and these people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kingdom.** Look up kingdom in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Xerxes gives these large banquets in Xerxes' palace. A palace is the house where the king lives. The palace is a large and important building where the king and his household stay and where the king rules.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **palace**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king gives royal wine to his guests at the banquet. Wine is a special drink that people make from grapes. People leave the juice for some time, and it becomes strong. Royal wine means wine that belongs to the king and comes from the king's own supply.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **royal wine**. Look up **wine** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king holds a banquet in the courtyard near the palace. A court or courtyard is an open space with no roof. Buildings or walls surround this space. People often build a courtyard with stone on the ground. Important gatherings can take place in this space.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **courtyard**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

People made the floor of the courtyard with different kinds of valuable stone materials. Marble is a smooth, hard stone, often white. Porphyry is a hard stone that looks red or purple. Mother-of-pearl is a smooth, shiny part inside a shell. People use these materials to make places look beautiful and rich.

Stop here and look as a group at pictures of pieces of marble, porphyry, and mother-of-pearl. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **marble**, **porphyry**, and **mother-of-pearl**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Esther 1:1–9

A mosaic is a kind of floor or wall decoration. Workers use the many small pieces of marble, porphyry, and mother-of-pearl in the floor. Workers place these pieces next to each other in patterns or pictures. This makes the surface look beautiful.

Stop here and look at a photo of a mosaic floor. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **mosaic**. Pause this audio here.

The king does not follow the usual rules for drinking at this banquet. Instead, the king gives an edict to his stewards. An edict is a special Persian word for a king's official command. People must obey this command.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **edict**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king gives the edict without compulsion. Compulsion means forcing someone to do something. In this story, there is no compulsion. So the king does not force people to drink. This means each person can choose how much to drink.

Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **compulsion**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A steward is a servant with an important role in the household. This person manages the work, gives instructions to other servants, and makes sure everything runs well.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **steward**. Look up steward in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Queen Vashti gives a separate banquet for the women in the palace. A queen is a woman who rules, or a woman who is the wife of a king. A queen is an important person and has a high position.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **queen**. Look up queen in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Esther 1:1–9

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Esther 1:10–22

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Esther 1:10—22 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:10—22 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:10—22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last part of the story, King Xerxes gave two banquets and showed his wealth and power to many people. At the same time, Queen Vashti gave a separate banquet for the women.

The story continues during the second banquet, which was the banquet for the people in the city. On the seventh day of the banquet, the king feels happy because he has drunk much wine. In that culture, people often drank wine at a banquet. Wine can make a person act in ways they would not normally act. Then the king gives a command to seven eunuchs. The eunuch's names are Mehuman, Biztha, Harbona, Bigtha, Abagtha, Zethar, and Carcas. Eunuchs are important servants who serve close to the king. These men cannot have children, because people have changed these men's bodies. Because these men cannot have children with the queen or the other women, the king can trust these men to work in that part of the palace. These eunuchs take care of the queen and carry messages for the king.

The king tells the eunuchs to bring Queen Vashti to the king. The king does not send the eunuchs to force the queen to come, but to lead her to the king. The king tells the eunuchs to put the royal crown on Queen Vashti's head. A crown shows that a person is a king or queen. This means that Queen Vashti should come dressed as queen, wearing her royal clothing and crown.

Stop here and look at a picture of a crown from that time. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what do your leaders wear to show that they are the rulers? Pause this audio here.

The king tells the eunuchs to show how beautiful the queen is to the people and the governors. The king wants to show the queen as part of the king's wealth and greatness. The story does not explain how the queen should come. Some scholars think the king may want to show the queen in a way that is not modest. The king may want the queen to come without a covering over her face, so that people can see the queen. This would go against the customs of that time. Other scholars think the king does not ask the queen to act in a way that is not modest,

but the queen may still feel shame if she shows herself in public, because people usually keep royal women hidden.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: In your community, do people ever show other people to show that they are important or wealthy? In your culture, when a leader calls someone to come so that the leader can show that person to other people, how might that person respond? What words do people use to show respect to a leader? Pause this audio here.

But Queen Vashti does not obey the king's command. The queen does not come. The storyteller does not explain why Queen Vashti refuses. The queen may not want to come before a group of men who have been drinking. The queen may not want the king to bring her out and show her to the people in this way. The storyteller does not give a clear reason.

Then the king becomes very angry. When kings like this become very angry, they can act in very cruel ways, so this is a dangerous moment for the people around the king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, is it acceptable to refuse to do what a leader or a husband asks you to do? Why or why not? Pause this audio here.

The king speaks to seven wise men who know the laws. These wise men's names are Carshena, Shethar, Admatha, Tarshish, Meres, Marsena and Memucan. These men from Persia and Media are important advisors who help the king make legal decisions. The king asks these men what the king should do because the king follows the law of the land. This is the normal way the king makes decisions.

One wise man, called Memucan, speaks to the king and the governors. Memucan says that Queen Vashti has done wrong. Memucan says that the queen has done wrong to the king. Memucan also says that the queen has done wrong to all the governors and all the people in all the provinces. Memucan says that the wives of the king's important governors in Persia and Media will hear about this. Then all women will hear about it. Then all women will not respect their husbands. Women will say that the king told Queen Vashti to come, but the queen did not come.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: In your culture, how do you know that a wife respects her husband? How do people show respect by what they say and do? Pause this audio here.

Memucan continues to speak. Memucan says that the wives of the governors will hear about this on the same day. These women will speak in the same way to their husbands. This will bring much trouble and much anger.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How might a small problem grow into a bigger problem in your community? Pause this audio here.

Memucan says that, if it pleases the king, the king should make a decree, or a written law. Memucan says to write this decree with the laws, or rules, of Persia and Media, so no one can change it. Memucan says that the decree should say that Vashti must never come before the king again. This means Vashti loses her place as queen and loses her honor and power. From this time, the people can no longer call Vashti the queen. Memucan says that the king should give Vashti's royal place to another woman who is better than Vashti. This likely means a woman who will obey the king. In this kingdom, a law that the king writes down and proclaims to the nation is very strong. When people write a decree like this, no one can change the decree, not even the king. In that culture, a king does not change his decision because this may bring shame to the king.

Memucan says that people will hear this decree in every part of the kingdom. All women will respect their husbands, whether their husbands are important or not important. The king and the governors agree with this advice. So the king makes this decree. The king's servants write the decree and tell it to all the people so that all people hear it. The king sends letters to all the provinces. The king sends the letters to each province in its own writing, and to each people in its own language. This shows that the kingdom has many different people and languages. The letters say that every man should rule in his own house. The Persian kingdom has a strong system for sending messages. Messengers travel quickly from place to place, even over long distances, so the king's commands can reach all parts of the kingdom.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: Talk about a time a ruler in your culture made a new law. How did the ruler talk about the new law? How did the ruler send the information about the new law to everyone? Pause this audio here.

This part of the story shows the power of the king and how the king uses that power. The king listens to advice and makes a law that affects all people in the kingdom. In the next part of the story, we will see how the king looks for a new queen who is better than Vashti.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:10—22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: On the seventh day of the banquet, King Xerxes drinks much wine and feels happy. The king gives a command to his eunuchs to bring Queen Vashti to the king. The king wants to show Vashti's beauty to the people and the officials.

In the second scene: Queen Vashti does not obey the king's command. Vashti does not come. Then the king becomes very angry, and the king's anger burns inside the king.

In the third scene: The king speaks to the wise men who know the laws. These men are important advisors who help the king make legal decisions. One man, Memucan, speaks to the king and the officials. Memucan says that Queen Vashti has done wrong, not only to the king, but also to all the people in the kingdom.

In the fourth scene: The king and the wise men agree with this advice. The king makes a law. The king sends letters to all the provinces in every language. The letters say that every man should rule in his own family.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- Queen Vashti
- The seven eunuchs who serve the king
- The wise men who advise the king, including Memucan
- The governors in the kingdom
- And the people in the provinces

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story follows the previous story. The previous story ended with the king having a banquet that lasted seven days. This story begins on the seventh day of that banquet in the king's palace in the city of Susa. The king is with many officials and people from the city. The setting is public, and many people can see what happens.

In the first scene, the storyteller names seven eunuchs. This shows that these men are important servants who work close to the king. The king trusts these men to carry his message. The king gives a command to these eunuchs.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, how do you list names in a story? Do you list all the names, or do you group the names together? How do you show that these people are important? Pause this audio here.

The king gives the command while he has been drinking wine. Think about how you can show that the king feels bold and acts quickly. The king commands the eunuchs to bring the queen to the banquet. Think about how you can show the eunuchs going to the queen to give the king's command.

The king wants the queen to come to the banquet to show her beauty. Think about how you can show the difference between the king's and the queen's status. The king has authority over the queen.

In the second scene, Queen Vashti refuses to come. The story does not explain why Vashti refuses. Think about how you can show that Vashti refuses. Think about how you can show the king's anger. The story says this in two ways: the king becomes very angry, and the king's anger burns inside the king.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words might people use to describe a woman who refuses a command like this? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and, as a group, tell a story about a time someone became very angry because someone else shamed that person in front of a lot of people. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use to talk about the person being angry. How can you talk about the king being so angry that the king's anger burned inside the king, like a fire burns hot? Think about how you can show strong anger in a clear way. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the king speaks to his advisors, or wise men. This is the normal way the king makes decisions. The king often has a group of seven advisors who are second only to the king, and people also call these men "governors." These men are very important and have special access to the king. The storyteller names these men. This shows that they are important men in the kingdom. These men know the times. This means the men understand what is happening and help the king decide what to do at the right time. The men also understand the laws and what is right and fair. The men help the king make decisions based on what the Persian law states.

Memucan, one of the seven advisors, speaks in front of the king and the other governors. Memucan speaks with respect, but he also speaks strongly. First, Memucan says that the queen has done wrong not only to the king, but to the governors, and then to the people. And like this, the problem will grow. The problem will likely move from the queen to the wives of important officials, and then to all women in the whole kingdom. All the women will hate their husbands. Think about how you can show this change from a small problem to a very big problem. Memucan uses strong words to describe what will happen. Memucan says there will be much disrespect and much anger. This shows that the problem will become very serious and will not stop.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, how do people speak about something that becomes very big or does not stop? What words or phrases show strong disrespect or anger? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and, as a group, practice retelling this part of the story so that you are showing that the problem starts with the queen, but then all the women will find out about the queen's disobedience. Pause this audio here.

Memucan speaks to the king with respect. Memucan begins his request in a careful way. Memucan says words like, "if it pleases the king." This is a polite way to speak to a ruler.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do people begin a request to a ruler or an important leader? What words show respect when someone speaks to a leader? How will you show this kind of respect in your language? Pause this audio here.

Memucan tells the king to make a decree. This is a formal decision. The king's servants will write the decree, and nobody can change the decree. The decree says that Vashti must not come before the king again, and the king gives Vashti's place to another woman. The decree also says that all women must respect their husbands, from the least important woman to the most important woman.

Think about how you can show a serious decree like this in your culture. Think about how you can show that this decree is for all people, both important people and not important people.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: In your culture, who makes laws or rules for the people? What words do people use for a law that no one can change? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, the king and his governors agree and make the decree. The king sends letters to all parts of the kingdom. Each place receives the message in its own language and in its own way of writing. Think about how you can show messages going out to many different places. The final command is that every man should rule his own family. The king has made a rule in the king's own palace that becomes a rule for every household in his kingdom.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How can you show that a message reaches all people in many places? Pause this audio here.

Think about how one part of the story leads to the next part. The story moves from a command to refusal to anger to advice to a decree, and then to the king sending a message to the whole kingdom. This story shows how a problem in the king's house becomes a rule for all people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you learn about King Xerxes from these scenes? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:10—22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- Queen Vashti
- The seven eunuchs who serve the king
- The wise men who advise the king, including Memucan
- The governors in the kingdom
- And the people in the provinces

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

King Xerxes drinks much wine and feels happy. The king gives a command to the eunuchs to bring Queen Vashti. The king wants to show Vashti's beauty to the people and the governors.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Xerxes, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy because I have been drinking; or
- I want people to see how beautiful the queen is; or
- I want people to see how great and powerful I am.

Ask the person playing the eunuchs, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I must obey the king's command; or
- I must go quickly to bring the queen; or
- I want to do my work well and please the king.

Continue the drama.

Queen Vashti does not come. Vashti does not obey the king's command.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Queen Vashti, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not want to go; or
- I do not want my husband to show me in front of all these people; or
- I feel ashamed to come in front of these men, because many of the men have been drinking.

Ask the person playing the eunuchs, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- The queen has refused; or
- I am worried to tell the king; or
- I must go back and report what happened.

Continue the drama.

The king hears that the queen has not come. The king becomes very angry. The king’s anger burns inside the king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Xerxes, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry because the queen did not obey me; or
- I feel ashamed because the queen did not obey me in front of all these people; or
- I must deal with this problem.

Continue the drama.

The king speaks to the wise men who know the laws. Memucan speaks to the king and the other wise men. Memucan says that this problem will spread from the queen to all women in the kingdom.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Memukan, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- This problem will become very big; or
- All women may stop obeying their husbands; or
- I must give advice so that people obey and do not cause problems.

Continue the drama.

Memucan tells the king to make a decree. Memucan says the queen must not come before the king again. Memucan says the king should give Vashti’s place to another woman.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Memucan, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am afraid of all the women who will begin to disobey us men! The king must act strongly; or
- The law must be clear; or
- This will stop the problem from growing.

Continue the drama.

The king agrees and makes the decree. The king sends letters to all the provinces in every language. The letters say that every man should rule his own family.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Xerxes, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I have made a strong decision; or
- All people will hear my command; or
- I am glad that I have shown my authority.

Ask the person playing the messengers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I must carry this message to many places; or
- I must make sure people understand the king’s command; or
- This message must reach everyone.

Esther 1:10–22

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Esther 1:10—22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this story, the **king** gives a command and sends for Queen Vashti. A king is a man who rules over a land and its people. A king has the authority to make decisions and give commands, and he expects people to obey the king. Use the same word or phrase for king that you used in the previous story, and refer to king in the Master Glossary for more information.

In this story, the king drinks **wine** during the feast. Wine is a drink that people make from grapes. Wine can make a person feel bold or less careful. Use the same word or phrase for wine as you used in the previous story. Wine is in the Master Glossary.

In this story, the king sends seven eunuchs to bring Queen Vashti. A eunuch is an important male servant who works very close to the king. These men cannot have children, because people have changed these men's bodies. Because these men cannot have children with the queen or the other women, the king trusts these men to work in that part of the palace.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **eunuch**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king gives a command to the eunuchs. A command is something a person with authority tells others to do. A leader expects his people to obey the leader's command.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **command**. Make sure the word shows strong authority. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king sends for **Queen** Vashti. A queen is a woman who has a royal position as the king's wife. A queen has honor and a high place in the kingdom. Use the same word or phrase for queen as you used in the previous story. Refer to queen in the Master Glossary for more information.

The king tells the eunuchs to put the royal crown on Queen Vashti's head. A crown is something a king or queen wears on the head. It shows that this person is the ruler. In this story, the king wants the people to see the queen as royal and important.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **crown,** and look at a photo of a crown again if needed. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king speaks to wise men to decide what to do. Wise men are important advisors who help the king make decisions. In this story, the wise men understand laws and help the king decide what to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wise men** or **advisors**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. For more information about how to call someone wise, refer to **wisdom** in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The wise men advise the king in matters of law. Laws are the rules that people must follow in the kingdom. These are the rules the king and his officials use to decide what people must do. This word for law is a special Persian word that only the Persian government used. You may use the same word that you used for God's law, but only if the word you use for God's law does not only mean a law from God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **law** in this story. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The wise men advise the king about justice. Justice means deciding what is right or wrong and giving a fair judgment. In some places, this may also mean following the customs of the people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **justice** or **judgment.** In your language, this may be a word for deciding what is right, or for following proper custom. Look up justice in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Memucan speaks about the wives of the king's **governors**, or princes, in Persia and Media. Governors are important people with a high position in the kingdom. Governors' wives are also important, and other people may follow what the governors' wives do. Use the same word for governors as you used in the previous passage.

The king sends letters to all parts of his **kingdom**. A kingdom is all the land and people that a king rules. A kingdom includes many places, cities, and groups of people under the king's authority. In this story, the kingdom is very large, so the message must reach many different people. Use the same word or phrase for kingdom as you used in the previous story. Refer to kingdom in the Master Glossary for more information.

The king makes a decree to send to all the people. A decree is a law that the king writes and announces to all people. A decree is an official message from the king.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **decree.** Pause this audio here.

A **province** is a smaller part of a large kingdom. The king divides the land into many parts, and each part has its own people and leaders. Use the same word or phrase for province as you used in previous passages.

The king sends letters, or small scrolls, to all the provinces. Each place receives the message in its own language and in its own way of writing. A way of writing means the form or system people use to write their words. Small scrolls are small pieces of parchment or animal skin that people roll up on both sides around sticks.

Stop here and look as a group at a photo of a scroll. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **scrolls** and **writing** or **script**. Refer to scroll in the Master Glossary for more information. If your language does not have a word for this, think about how you can explain it clearly. Pause this audio here.

The law says that every man should rule his own household. A household means the people who live together in one home, such as a husband, wife, children, and others in the family. In this story, it means the man leads and makes decisions for his family.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **household**. Make sure the word shows a group of people living together, not just a building. Look up household in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king sends the message to each people group in their own language, or "tongue." Tongue means the way people speak in their own group. In this story, the king wants every group to hear the message in words the people understand.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **language** or **tongue**. Look up tongue in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Media Requests

A picture of a scroll (as inserted by Tricia)

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Esther 1:10–22

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1002 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Esther 2:1–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Esther 2:1—11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:1—11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous part of this story, King Xerxes removed Queen Vashti. King Xerxes made a decree so that Vashti could not come before Xerxes again. Now the king has no queen. After these things, King Xerxes's anger becomes calm. Some years pass after the king removes Vashti. Some scholars think that during this time, the king went away to fight a war. Later, the king returned to his palace. The king remembers Vashti and what she did. The king also remembers the law against Vashti. The story does not say that the king brings Vashti back. The law cannot change. Even the king does not change it.

Esther 2:1–11

Then the king's servants speak to the king and suggest a plan. The servants say that people should look for young women for the king. The servants say the women should be beautiful virgins. In other words, these women should not have had sexual relations with a man. The servants tell the king to send officials to every province. These officials will gather the young women and bring these women to the king's palace in the city of Susa. The officials go to every province and take the young women. The young women do not choose to go to the king's palace.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the Persian kingdom. Find the city of Susa. See how large the kingdom is and think about how far the women will travel to reach the king. Pause this audio here.

The women will stay in a place called the harem, a place where the king keeps women. The women live in comfort, but the women do not live like a family. The women do not have a husband in the normal way, and the women can only see the king if the king calls them.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What freedom do these women have? What are these women not able to do? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: In your culture, can one man have many women in his household? If so, what do other people in your community think about this? Pause this audio here.

The servants say that a man called Hegai will care for the women. Hegai is a eunuch, an important servant who works closely with the king. You will remember that a man who is a eunuch cannot have children, because people have changed this man's body. Because this man cannot have children with the queen or the other women, the king can trust this man to work in that part of the palace. The servants say that Hegai will give beauty treatments to the women. Then the king will choose one woman to be queen instead of Vashti.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: In your culture, how do leaders choose people for important roles? Do people have a choice, or do leaders decide? How might people feel when people take them far from home to serve a leader? Pause this audio here.

This plan pleases the king. So the king gives an order. Then, officials gather many young women. The officials bring the women to Susa, to the king's palace. The officials place the women under Hegai's care.

At this time, a Jewish man lives in Susa. This man's name is Mordecai. Mordecai comes from the family line of Benjamin, one of the tribes of Israel. The king of Babylon had taken Mordecai's family away from Jerusalem many years before. This happened when King Nebuchadnezzar took people from Jerusalem to Babylon.

Mordecai cares for a young woman called Esther. Esther is the daughter of Mordecai's uncle. Esther's Hebrew name is Hadassah. Esther's father and mother had died. So Mordecai had taken Esther as his own daughter and cared for Esther.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: In your community, who cares for a child when the child's mother and father die? Pause this audio here.

When the king's order goes out, officials take Esther to the king's palace. Esther goes to the place where the women stay. Hegai cares for Esther. Hegai is pleased with Esther. Hegai chooses to help Esther. Hegai gives Esther the best food that comes from the king's house. Hegai gives Esther oil and other things to put on her body. Some of these oils come from plants, such as myrrh, and these oils have a strong, good smell. Women use these things to clean the body, make the skin soft, and make the body smell good. Women put these oils on their bodies again and again over many months. Hegai gives Esther seven female servants from the king's palace. This shows that Hegai treats Esther in a special way. Not every woman receives this, so Hegai is already treating Esther like an important woman. Then Hegai moves Esther and her servants to a better place in the harem.

Mordecai has told Esther not to tell people that Esther is Jewish. So Esther does not tell anyone about her people or her family. Every day, Mordecai walks near the courtyard of the harem. Mordecai wants to know if Esther is safe. Mordecai wants to know what happens to Esther.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: Why do you think Mordecai tells Esther to hide where her relatives come from? In your culture, why might people hide where they come from? Pause this audio here.

This part of the story shows how Esther comes to the king's palace. Esther does not choose this, but Hegai shows kindness to Esther, and Mordecai continues to care for her. In the next part of the story, we will see what happens when the king begins to meet the women.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Some years pass after the king sends Vashti away and the king's anger becomes calm. The king remembers Vashti and what happened to Vashti. Then the king's servants speak to the king and suggest a plan to find a new queen.

In the second scene: The king agrees with the plan. The king asks his officials to go to every part of the kingdom to gather many young women and bring the women to the king's palace. The women go to the harem, the place where the king keeps his women. The women do not choose to go; the king's officials take the women.

In the third scene: The story now stops and introduces new people. At this time, a Jewish man whom people call Mordecai lives in Susa. Mordecai cares for a young woman whom people call Esther. Esther has no father and no mother, so Mordecai has been raising Esther as his own daughter. Esther is beautiful.

In the fourth scene: The story returns to the king's command. When the people hear the king's command, the officials take Esther to the palace. Esther goes to the place where the women stay. Hegai cares for the women. Hegai sees Esther and is pleased with her. Hegai chooses to help Esther. Hegai gives Esther good food from the king's house. Hegai gives Esther oil and other things to put on her body. Hegai gives Esther seven servant girls. Hegai moves Esther to a better place.

In the fifth scene: Mordecai had told Esther not to tell anyone about her people or her family. Esther obeys Mordecai. Every day, Mordecai walks back and forth near the courtyard. Mordecai watches to see if Esther is safe.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- The king's servants who suggest a plan to the king
- The king's officials who bring the young women to the palace
- Hegai, the king's eunuch
- The seven female servants Hegai assigned to Esther
- Mordecai
- Esther
- And the young women the officials brought to the palace

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story takes place in the city of Susa, at the king's palace. Some parts of the story happen in public places, and some parts happen inside the place where the women stay.

In the first scene, the king remembers Vashti. In other words, the king thinks about what Vashti has done and what the king has decreed about Vashti. The king's anger becomes calm. In the last part of the story, the king's anger burned. Now it becomes quiet over time.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about a time when someone was very angry and later became calm. How did people describe that change? What words or pictures do people use in your language? How will you describe the king's anger becoming calm? Pause this audio here.

The servants suggest a plan to the king. The servants speak to the king as if the king were someone the servants were talking about rather than talking to. This is a special way of talking to someone who is much greater than the servants are.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the way the servants speak to the king. Pause this audio here.

The servants ask the king to search for beautiful young women who are also virgins. The king should appoint leaders, or government officials, in every province of the kingdom to find the beautiful women and bring them to the harem in the stronghold of Susa. You will remember that a harem is a place where a king keeps women.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you talk about beautiful women in your language. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the harem, or the place where the king keeps his women. Remember that the women live in comfort, but they are not free to leave. Pause this audio here.

The servants say that the king should put Hegai, the king's eunuch, in charge of the women and give them beauty treatments. People put special oils and perfumes on women to make their skin shine and make them look and smell more beautiful.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the beauty treatments that the women received. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller says that the king agrees and does what the servants suggest. The storyteller does not describe each action that the king does. We simply know that these actions happened. Think about how you can show the officials taking women from many different places. Think about how you can show that the women do not choose this. The women go to the harem. The women live under the king's authority. The women have food and a place to live, but they do not live like a family.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, how will you make sure it is clear that the king agreed with his advisors and made the suggestions happen? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the storyteller stops to introduce Mordecai and Esther. Mordecai's family line goes back many years. The story says that the king of Babylon took someone from Mordecai's family away from Jerusalem when the king of Babylon took people into exile. This did not happen in Mordecai's own lifetime. It must have been one of Mordecai's ancestors that the king of Babylon took away.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people speak about something that happened many years before someone was born? Pause this audio here.

Esther has no parents, so Mordecai cares for Esther. Esther is Mordecai's cousin. The storyteller says that Esther is the daughter of Mordecai's uncle. The storyteller does not say if this uncle is from Mordecai's father's side or mother's side.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, how do you speak about a cousin? Do you need to say which side of the family this person comes from? How will you describe this relationship clearly? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: You previously talked about who might care for a child when the child's mother and father die. What words do people use for this kind of care? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, Esther comes to the palace. The storyteller uses two ways to describe Esther. The storyteller says that Esther is lovely in her body and beautiful in her appearance. These two descriptions are similar but not exactly the same.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your language describe someone's body and someone's general appearance? Do you use one word or phrase, or two different ways to say this? Pause this audio here.

Esther pleases Hegai, which means she looks beautiful to him, so Hegai chooses to help Esther. In other words, Esther wins Hegai's favor, so he treats Esther in a special way. Hegai gives Esther seven servant girls from the king's palace, and Hegai moves Esther to a special place in the harem building. Think about how you can show that one person receives special care.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Why might someone choose to help one person more than others? Pause this audio here.

Mordecai tells Esther not to tell anyone about her people and family. The storyteller uses two ideas here. One refers to Esther's people, which means her general race or nationality. The other refers to Esther's family, which means her family line or relatives. These are not exactly the same.

[Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, do you use one word or two different words for these ideas? How will you describe both Esther's people and her family clearly? Pause this audio here.]{.mark}

[We are not sure when Mordecai tells Esther this. Mordecai probably told Esther before they took her to the palace, but the storyteller does not tell us.]{.mark} Think about how you can show someone giving a strong command and another person obeying.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that Mordecai strongly forbade Esther from sharing her nationality and family line. Pause this audio here.

Every day, Mordecai walks near the courtyard of the place where the women stay. A courtyard is an open space inside a building, with rooms around it. People can walk there and sometimes speak to others through doors or windows. Mordecai may stay near this place so he can hear news about Esther or see her from a distance. Mordecai watches to see if Esther is safe. Think about how you can show someone checking something again and again.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people show care for someone who is far away or in danger? Pause this audio here.

Think about how one part of the story leads to the next part. The story moves from the king remembering, to a plan, to gathering women, to Esther coming to the palace, and then to Mordecai watching and waiting.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What do you learn about the king and about Mordecai from these scenes? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- The king's servants who suggest a plan to the king
- The king's officials who bring the young women to the palace
- Hegai, the king's eunuch
- The seven female servants Hegai assigned to Esther
- Mordecai
- Esther
- And the young women the officials brought to the palace

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses:

The king remembers Vashti and how he sent Vashti away. The servants speak to the king and tell him how to find a new queen.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer:

- I remember what happened with Vashti; or
- I now feel regret about my decision; or
- I want to find a new queen.

Continue the drama.

The king sends his officials. The officials gather the young women and take the women to the palace.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the young women, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer:

- I do not want to be here. I did not choose this; or
- I feel afraid; or
- I do not know what will happen to me; or
- I am happy. Now maybe I will get more opportunities to have nice things.

Continue the drama.

Mordecai cares for Esther. Esther has no father and no mother.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Mordecai, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer:

- I must care for Esther; or
- I want to protect Esther and make sure that she is safe; or
- Esther is like my own daughter.

Continue the drama.

Hegai sees Esther and decides to help her. Hegai gives Esther food, beauty treatments, servants, and a better place.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hegai, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer:

- I see something special in Esther; or
- I want to help this young girl; or
- I choose to give Esther the best care I can.

Continue the drama.

Mordecai tells Esther not to tell anyone about her people. Esther obeys Mordecai.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Esther, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer:

- I want to obey Mordecai; or
- I wonder why Mordecai did not want me to tell anyone? or
- I trust Mordecai.

Continue the drama.

Mordecai walks back and forth each day. Mordecai watches to see if Esther is safe.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Mordecai, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer:

- I want to know that Esther is safe; or
- I care about Esther very much; or
- I will keep watching carefully over Esther.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Xerxes remembered Vashti and what Vashti had done. Translate king in the same way as you have previously, and remember that king is in the Master Glossary.

In this story, the city of Susa is the strong place where the king lives and rules, or a **stronghold**. A stronghold is a place with strong walls where people stay safe from enemies. It is hard for enemies to enter. Look up stronghold in the Master Glossary for more information. Use the same word or phrase for stronghold as you used in previous passages.

In this story, the king made a decision about Vashti and said that decision as a **decree**. To "decree" means that a king makes an official decision and speaks it out. After this, people must obey that decision. Use the same word or phrase for decree as you used in previous passages.

The king's servants are men who work for the king and serve him in the palace. These servants stay near the king and help him. The servants speak to the king with respect and give him advice. In this story, these servants suggest a plan to find a new queen.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the king's **servants**. How do people in your language speak about people who serve a king or leader? Look up servant in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king's servants tell the king to appoint officials to go to all parts of the kingdom. These officials work for the king and follow his instructions. The king sends the officials to different places to do the king's work. In this story, the officials go to find the young women and bring them to the **palace**. Use the same word or phrase for palace, or king's house, as you have used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for these **officials**. What do you call people who work for a ruler and do his work? If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A **province** is a smaller part of a large kingdom. The king divides the land into many parts, and each part has its own people and leaders. In this story, the king sends officials to every province. Use the same word or phrase for province as you used in previous passages.

The king's **command** or **law** is something the king tells people to do. People must obey it. In this story, the king gives orders so that people go to all parts of the kingdom and bring the women. Use the same word or phrase for command or law as you used in previous passages.

A **queen** is the king's wife who has a special place and honor in the kingdom. In this story, the king looks for a new queen to take Vashti's place. Look up queen in the Master Glossary for more information. Use the same word for queen as you used in previous passages.

A harem is a place inside the king's palace where the king keeps his women. This place is separate from other parts of the palace. It is sometimes called "The House of the Women." Guards control who can go in and out. The king rules over these women. The women do not live with a husband in the normal way, and the women can only go to the king if the king calls them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **harem**. Pause this audio here.

A virgin is a young woman who has not had sexual relations with a man. In this story, the virgins are the young women the officials bring to the king.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for a **virgin**. Make sure the word clearly shows that the woman has not had sexual relations. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Esther 2:1–11

A **eunuch** is a trusted servant who works very close to the king. A eunuch serves in the king's house and carries out the king's commands. The king trusts the eunuch with important tasks. The eunuch may guard parts of the palace and control who can enter. The eunuch may also take care of the women and watch over them. Use the same word or phrase for eunuch as you used in previous passages.

The story says that Mordecai is the son of Jair, the son of Shimei, the son of Kish. In the Bible, "son of" can mean a direct son or a descendant from the same family line. We are not sure if Jair, Shimei, and Kish are direct ancestors of Mordecai or not.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate "son of." Will you describe a direct son, or a descendant from a family line? Look up **descendant** in the Master Glossary for more information, and use a word that can mean that Mordecai is either a son or a descendant of these men. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller speaks about Jehoiachin, king of Judah. Judah is the name of the land and the people who lived there. You will remember that the nation of Israel had divided into a northern and a southern kingdom. Enemies came at different times and took people from both kingdoms into exile. People knew the Israelites from the southern kingdom as "Jews." Mordecai and the Jews in the Persian empire are from the southern kingdom of Judah.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate **Judah** and **Jew**. Look up Judah and Jew in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word or phrase for Judah as you have used previously. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that enemies took people away from Jerusalem, the capital of Judah, and brought them to another land. This is called "exile"—when a powerful king takes people away from their home and forces them to live in another place.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **exile**. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word. If not, think about how to describe how enemies take people far away from their home by force. Pause this audio here.

To show favor means to choose to help someone or to treat someone well. In this story, Hegai shows favor to Esther and chooses to help her.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **favor.** How do people in your language show that one person receives special care? If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Cosmetics or beauty treatments are oils and other things that people put on the body. People use these things to clean the body, to make the skin soft, and to make the body smell good. In this story, the women in the harem use these things to prepare to meet the king.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **cosmetics** or **beauty treatments.** If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Esther receives seven of her own young female attendants, or servants, who help Esther and serve her in the palace. Attendants are usually young people who stay near an important person and serve them. Attendants listen to what the person says and do what the person asks. Attendants help with daily needs and carry messages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **attendants**. If needed, you may use a word for female **servants**. If you use the word for servants, refer to the Master Glossary for more information about servants. If you have already translated the idea of young female attendants in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Esther 2:1–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.0 MB)
- Setting the Stage (4.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (6.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Esther 2:12–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Esther 2:12—18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:12—18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:12—18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous part of this story, the king chose to find a new queen. The king's servants brought many young women to the citadel of Susa. These women stayed in the king's house, and a man called Hegai cared for the women. Hegai was one of the king's eunuchs. A eunuch is an important servant who works very close to the king and serves in the king's house.

Esther 2:12–18

In this part of the story, each young woman prepares for a long time before she goes to the king. The time of preparation lasts for 12 months. This long time of preparation helps each woman get ready to meet the king. The king's house is very rich, and the women prepare carefully so the king will see them as beautiful and pleasing. This is the rule in the king's house, and each young woman must complete this time. Some scholars think this long time also helped make sure a woman was not already pregnant before she went to the king. But the storyteller does not say this clearly.

For the first six months of preparation, the women use oils. The weather is hot and dry, so people use oils to keep the skin soft. Myrrh is a kind of oil or resin that comes from a plant. Myrrh has a strong smell that people use on the body. For the next six months, the women use perfumes and other beauty treatments. Beauty treatments are special ways to wash and prepare the body so a person looks and smells good.

Stop here and look at a picture of a myrrh tree as a group. Look at the bark and any liquid that comes out of the tree when people cut the tree. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people prepare for an important meeting or event? What do people do to look or smell good? Pause this audio here.

After this time of preparation, each woman goes, one by one, to the king when her time comes. Each woman goes at night and spends one night with the king as his wife for that night. Each young woman has one opportunity to please the king. When a woman goes to the king, she can take with her anything she asks for from the house of the women. The story does not say what the women choose to take, but these things may help them look beautiful or special.

After that night, the woman returns to a second house for the women. Another eunuch of the king, whose name is Shaashgaz, cares for these women. These women do not return to the king again unless the king calls the woman by name because he wants her. The king does not call for just any woman. The king calls one woman by name. This shows that the king remembers that woman, chooses her, and gives her permission to come to the king. But this also means each woman usually has only one time to go to the king. Although these women stay in the king's house for the rest of their lives, the king will not choose most of these women again. This also means that these women cannot marry anyone else.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How might a young woman feel in this situation? What thoughts or fears might the woman have? Pause this audio here.

Esther is one of these young women. Esther is the daughter of Mordecai's uncle Abihail, and Mordecai has raised Esther as his own daughter. When it is Esther's turn to go to the king, Esther asks for only the things that Hegai advises Esther to bring. Hegai is the man who cares for the women, and Hegai knows what pleases the king. Esther listens to Hegai and follows his advice. All the people who see Esther like her and think she is beautiful.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why do you think Esther listens to Hegai? Talk about a time you listened to wise advice. What happened as a result? Pause this audio here.

Servants bring Esther to King Xerxes in the 10th month of the year. The Persians call this month "Tebeth." This happens in the seventh year of the king's rule. The king is attracted to Esther more than all the other women and chooses Esther above all the others. So the king chooses Esther to be queen instead of Vashti. The king places the royal crown on Esther's head and makes Esther queen. A crown is something a king places on a person's head to show that this person now has a high position as queen.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a royal crown. Talk about what people in your culture use to show that a person is a leader or has authority. Pause this audio here.

Then the king gives a great banquet for all his governors, or high officials, and his other servants, or officials. This banquet is to honor Esther. The king also gives rest from work to people in the provinces, and the king gives many gifts. The storyteller does not say clearly who receives these gifts. The king may give these gifts to people across his kingdom. This shows that the king is kind and generous.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture celebrate when something important happens? What do people give or do to show joy? Pause this audio here.

This part of the story shows how Esther becomes queen. Esther follows Hegai's advice, and the king is pleased with Esther. In the next part of the story, we will see how Esther's place in the palace becomes very important.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:12—18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Each young woman prepares for 12 months before she goes to the king. The women use perfumes, oils, and other beauty treatments. The women follow the rules in the king's house.

In the second scene: Each woman goes and spends one night with the king as his wife for that night. Each young woman has one opportunity to please the king. After that night, the woman goes to another part of the king's house. The woman does not return to the king again unless the king calls that woman by name.

In the third scene: Esther goes to the king. Esther listens to Hegai and follows his advice. All the people who see Esther like Esther. The king loves Esther more than all the other women, and the king chooses Esther to be queen. The king places a crown on Esther's head.

In the fourth scene: The king gives a great banquet for his governors and officials to honor Esther. The king gives rest from work to the people in the provinces and gives gifts. The king shows generosity.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- Hegai, the king's eunuch
- Shaashgaz, the king's eunuch
- Esther
- The young women in the king's house
- The king's governors and officials
- And the people in the king's provinces

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This part of the story takes place in the king's palace in Susa. The story moves between different parts of the king's house: where the women stay and where the king lives.

In the first scene, the women prepare for 12 months. Think about how you can show a long time passing. Think about how you can show the women using oil and perfume on their bodies. The king's servants tell the women what to use. The women must follow these instructions. The women do not choose for themselves.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you say that the king's servants give instructions and the women must obey? What words will you use to show that the women do not choose for themselves? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kinds of oils, perfumes, or smells do people use in your culture? How do you talk about these things? What words do you use to describe these things? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, each woman goes to the king one by one. Think about how you can show the women waiting and taking turns. The same thing happens for each woman. Think about how you can show this pattern: Each woman goes to the king one time. Each woman spends one night with the king. Each woman has one chance to please the king.

Each woman goes at night and returns in the morning. Think about how you can describe night and morning. The women then go to another part of the king's house and stay there.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How does a person feel when that person must wait for a turn to do something important? Pause this audio here.

Esther 2:12–18

After that night, the women go to another part of the king's house and stay there. These women belong to the king and live in the king's house as his wives, but these women are not the queen.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What would you call these women in your language? How will you describe their place in the king's house so people understand that these women belong to the king but that none of them is the queen? Pause this audio here.

It is important to notice that in the first and second scenes, the storyteller explains what usually happens to the women in the harem. In the third scene, the storyteller turns to Esther. Think about how you can show this change. Esther goes to the king. The storyteller reminds the listeners that Esther is the young woman Mordecai raised and that Esther is the daughter of Mordecai's uncle Abihail.

Stop here and discuss as a group: When your people tell a story, how do they remind listeners who a person is? Where do they put this kind of information in the story? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller also gives the time. This happens in the seventh year of the king's rule. This is four years after the king sent Vashti away.

Stop here and discuss as a group: When you tell a story, how do you show time? Where do you put this kind of time information? Pause this audio here.

Esther acts differently from the other women. Esther does not choose things for herself. Esther takes only what Hegai tells Esther to take. Esther listens to Hegai and follows his advice. Think about how you can describe someone trusting another person's advice. Think about how you can describe that one person is different from the others.

People see Esther. People like Esther. People feel pleased when they see Esther. Esther wins favor with everyone who sees Esther.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, how do people speak about a person like this? Think about a person who meets important people and wins their favor. How do people describe that kind of person? How will you describe Esther so listeners understand this clearly? Pause this audio here.

The king sees Esther. The king is attracted to Esther and loves her more than the other women. This is mostly a sexual or physical attraction.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, how do people speak about this kind of physical attraction between a man and a woman? What words will your people use so listeners understand this clearly? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, the king gives a great banquet. Many people gather, including the king's high officials, the governors. The king also calls his other officials who work for the king. Think about how you can show a large celebration. The king gives the people in the provinces rest from work and gives gifts. The story does not say clearly who receives these gifts. The king may give these gifts to people throughout his kingdom.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do people speak about a special day when people rest and celebrate? What words do they use? When an important person gives gifts to many people, how do people describe this? What words show that the giver is important? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller shows again that the king is kind and generous. The storyteller has said this before in the story.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, when a storyteller repeats something about a person, how do you show this? Do you say that thing again in the same way, or do you change the words? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you show that the king is a person who gives freely and treats people well? Pause this audio here.

Think about how one part of the story leads to the next part. The story moves from preparing to go in to the king, to meeting the king, to life after meeting the king, to Esther, and then to celebrating Esther as queen. The story builds step by step and leads to the moment when the king chooses Esther.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What is different about Esther compared to the other women? Pause this audio here.

Esther 2:12–18

At the beginning of the story, the women stay in private rooms in the king's house. People do not see what happens there. At the end of the story, the king gives a great banquet. Many people gather, and everyone can see what happens. So, the story moves from hidden places to a public celebration. Think about how you can show the change. How will you show that only a few people see at the beginning, but many people see at the large banquet at the end?

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:12—18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- Hegai, the king's eunuch
- Shaashgaz, the king's eunuch
- Esther
- The young women in the king's house
- The king's governors and officials
- And the people in the king's provinces

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer things like what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Each young woman prepares for a long time before she goes to the king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the women, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I must wait a long time; or
- I want to be ready for the king; or
- I feel nervous about what will happen when it is my time to go.

Continue the drama.

Each woman goes to the king for one night.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the women, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is my one chance; or
- I very much want the king to choose me; or
- I feel afraid about the future.

Continue the drama.

After that night, the woman goes to another place and does not return.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the women, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I will not return to the king; or
- I will stay here now; or
- My life has changed forever.

Continue the drama.

The king sees Esther and chooses her.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer things like:

- I like Esther so much more than the others; or
- I love Esther; or
- I will make Esther my queen.

Continue the drama.

The king gives a great banquet and gives gifts.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing someone from the provinces, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am joyful because the king gives us rest; or
- I am so happy; or
- We must celebrate Queen Esther!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:12—18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this story, each young **virgin** goes to the **king** after many months of preparation. Use the same words for virgin and king as you did in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

The women wash their bodies and prepare themselves so they look and smell good. The women use oils and perfumes, like myrrh, for many months. These **beauty treatments** are special ways to wash and prepare the body so a person looks and smells good. Use the same word or phrase for “beauty treatments” as you used in previous passages.

Myrrh comes from a small tree. People cut the bark of the tree, and a thick liquid comes out. This liquid dries and becomes myrrh. Myrrh has a strong smell, so people use myrrh on the body. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Stop here and look again at a picture of some myrrh as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **myrrh**. If there is no word for myrrh, you may describe it as a strong-smelling oil from a tree. Pause this audio here.

The king had servants called **eunuchs** who worked for him in the **king’s palace**. A eunuch is an important servant who works very close to the king. In this story, eunuchs care for the women and carry out the king’s instructions. Use the same words or phrases for eunuch and king’s palace as you used in previous passages.

After a woman goes to the king, she does not return to her family. The woman goes to another house in the king’s palace called a **harem**. Use the same word or phrase for harem as you used in previous passages. The woman lives in the harem as a concubine. A concubine is a woman who belongs to the king and lives with the king as a wife of lower rank. The woman only goes back to the king if the king calls the woman again.

Esther 2:12–18

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **concubine**. Make sure the word does not suggest that the woman has done something wrong, but shows her place in the king's house. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A **crown** is something a king places on a person's head to show that person has authority. In this story, the king places a crown on Esther's head to show that Esther is now **queen**. Use the same word for crown and queen as you did in previous passages. For more information on queen, refer to the Master Glossary.

A **banquet** is a large meal where many people gather to eat and celebrate. In this story, the king is pleased with Esther, so the king gives a banquet to honor Esther. Use the same word or phrase for banquet as you used in previous passages.

The king also gives the people in the provinces a special day, or a holiday. The people stop their normal work. The people rest, celebrate, or spend time with others.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **holiday**. Think about days when people in your culture might stop work and celebrate. Pause this audio here.

The king gives gifts to people in all the provinces. The king gives gifts to the **governors**, or high **officials**, and to the king's other officials. These leaders and officials serve under the king and carry out the king's work in different places. Sometimes people call these officials servants. Use the same word or phrase for governors and officials as you used in previous passages.

Media Requests:

A close-up image of the bark of a myrrh tree, showing resin coming out

A royal crown for a woman in Persia at that time

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Esther 2:12–18

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.0 MB)

- Setting the Stage (4.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Esther 2:19–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Esther 2:19—23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:19—23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:19—23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous part of this story, King Xerxes chose Esther to be queen from among many young women who came to the palace. The king placed a royal crown on Esther's head and gave a banquet to honor Esther.

Esther now lives in the king's house as queen. The king still has great control. Mordecai, Esther's cousin, stays near the king's gate. Esther still does not tell anyone that she is Jewish. Esther obeys Mordecai, just as she did before. Esther probably remembers the things that Mordecai taught Esther when she was young. Mordecai raised Esther and taught her how to live as part of the Jewish people, so Esther continues to listen to Mordecai and follow his instructions, just as Esther did when she lived in Mordecai's house.

The storyteller says that the young women gather for a second time, but the storyteller does not explain this clearly. It may mean that the king's servants bring together more young women again, even after Esther becomes queen.

In this part of the story, Mordecai sits at the king's gate. The king's gate is an important place at the entrance to the palace. Officials and servants pass through this place each day. Some servants sit there to watch, listen, report news, and help with the king's business. This may mean Mordecai has some kind of official role in the government, but the storyteller does not say this clearly. But Mordecai is in a place where he can hear what happens in the palace and any important news.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a large city gate or palace gate. Notice how big the gate is and how many people can pass through the gate. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Mordecai sits at the king's gate, where people hear news and talk about important matters. In your culture, where do people go to hear news or talk about important things? Pause this audio here.

Two of the king's officials, called Bigthana and Teresh, become angry with the king. These men are probably eunuchs, and these men guard the entrance of the palace and protect the king. These men make a secret plan

to kill the king. In those days, people sometimes made plans like this against a king. The storyteller does not tell us why these men feel angry, but these men decide to act against the king.

Mordecai hears about this plan. We do not know how Mordecai learns this news. Mordecai may hear this news at the gate, or someone may tell Mordecai. The storyteller does not tell us. But Mordecai understands that this is serious and chooses to act. Mordecai tells Queen Esther about the plan.

Esther tells the king about the danger. The king is a very powerful ruler, and people do not speak to the king in a casual way. But Esther has a special place as queen. Esther tells the king that Mordecai heard this news and that Mordecai gave her this information. Esther does not take the honor for herself.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Mordecai tells Esther, and Esther tells the king. In your culture, how do people pass important news to a leader? Can anyone speak directly, or must the message go through others? Pause this audio here.

The king checks if the report is true and finds that the report is true. The king then punishes the two men. The king orders that these men die because these men planned to kill the king. People impaled these men on a pole. The king's servants place the men's bodies on the wood, often on a sharp point, and lift the pole up high so others can see it. This shames the men and their families and warns other people not to do wrong or make a plan against the king like these men.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In this part of the story, the king badly punishes the men who plan to kill the king. In your culture, what might happen when someone plans to harm a leader or another person? Pause this audio here.

The king's servants write this event in the book of history with the king there. This book is an official record. The king's servants write down important events in this book so that the king can remember these things later and act on them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In this story, the king writes this event in a record so the king can remember it. In your culture, how do people remember important events? Do people write things down, or remember in other ways? Why might people write down important events, and what might people do about these events later? Pause this audio here.

This part of the story shows that Mordecai protects the king. Mordecai does what is right. Esther speaks to the king at the right time, and the king learns the truth. The king records this event. This official record will become very important later.

In the next part of the story, a new leader will become powerful in the king's palace. This man will not like Mordecai, and this man's anger will bring danger not only to Mordecai but to many people.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:19—23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The young women gather a second time. Mordecai sits at the king's gate. Esther still does not tell anyone that she is Jewish. Esther obeys Mordecai.

In the second scene: As Mordecai sits at the king's gate, two of the king's trusted servants, named Bigthana and Teresh, guard the entrance. These men become angry and make a plan to harm the king. Mordecai learns about the plan.

In the third scene: Mordecai tells Queen Esther about the plan. Queen Esther tells the king. Esther tells the King that Mordecai gave Esther that information.

In the fourth scene: The king investigates the report and finds that it is true. The king orders that the men die. The king's servants fix the men's bodies onto wooden poles and lift them up high so that people can see the men's bodies.

In the fifth scene: The king's servants write about this event in the book of history, with the king there watching.

The characters in this passage are:

- The young women who gather
- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- Mordecai
- Queen Esther
- The two eunuchs, Bigthana and Teresh
- And the king's servants

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting and how the story moves step by step.

In the first scene, the story gives background information again. Mordecai sits at the gate, and Esther keeps her identity secret. The storyteller repeats this information so the listener remembers it.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Why do you think the storyteller repeats this information about Esther and Mordecai? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller begins to tell the problem. The storyteller says, "In those days," and then tells what happens. Two servants, who are probably eunuchs, become angry with the king. These servants guard the entrance to the king's house. The two men speak together in secret and make a plan to harm the king. The men agree together, and the men hide this plan from others.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for making a secret plan to harm someone else. Make sure the word shows that the plan is secret and involves more than one person. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller shows what the men plan to do. The men plan to kill the king, or "lay hands on him." This is what it means to assassinate.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the idea that the men will assassinate, or kill, an important leader. If there is no word for this, you may say "to kill a leader" or "to kill the king." Pause this audio here.

Mordecai learns about the plan. Notice that the storyteller says Mordecai sits at the gate again. The same place appears again. Mordecai sits at the king's gate because Mordecai may have a special role or duty there. The king's gate is a place where officials sit and do the king's work.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, where do leaders or officials sit to do their work? How would you describe a place like this? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells the names of the two men who make the plan. The men are named Bigthana and Teresh. The storyteller gives the men's names, not just the men's actions. This may help the listeners see that these are real people in the story. You will remember that kings in that time often used eunuchs to serve them, because someone had changed the eunuchs' bodies so that they could not have children.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, when storytellers give names, what does that show? Do storytellers always give names, or only at important times? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the storyteller shows how the message moves step by step. Mordecai tells Esther. Esther tells the king. Esther tells the king that Mordecai gave Esther this information.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out how the message moves from Mordecai to Esther, and from Esther to the king. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, the king acts. The king gives an order to check if the report from Mordecai, through Esther, is true. The king's servants investigate the matter and find that it is true. The king then gives an order. The king's servants do the action and kill the two men. People can see what happens. The result is public.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, how do people speak about checking a report or investigating something to see if that thing is true? Who usually does this work? Pause this audio here.

The king's servants kill the two men. The servants put the men's bodies on a tall, sharp pole. The servants lift the bodies and put them on the pole so people can see the bodies. The pole stands in a public place where many people pass by. Sometimes people hang a dead body on a pole or tree. Other times, people use a sharp pole and push the body onto it while the person is still alive. The person would hang there until they died. The words in this story do not make it clear exactly how the servants put the men's bodies on the poles.

Stop and, as a group, look at a picture of this sort of pole. Remember that the pole was 50 cubits high, which is about 22 to 23 meters. This is about the height of a seven or eight-story building. It is much taller than a normal tree and nearby houses, and people far away could easily see something that high. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your language, what word will your people use for this kind of pole? How will people describe this action clearly, so listeners understand what happens to the two men? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, the story slows down. The servants write the event in a record in the presence of the king. The servants likely write this on a scroll. A scroll is a long piece of prepared animal skin or paper. People roll it up at both ends. When people read a scroll, people unroll one side and roll up the other side. The story ends with servants writing this event in the book of the history of the king. This shows that the event is important and the kings will not forget the event.

Think about how the story moves from one part to the next. First, the story repeats the situation. Then a problem begins. After that, a message moves from one person to another until it reaches the king. Then the king acts, and people can see the result. At the end, the servants write the event in a record so no one will forget it. The story moves from a public place, to a secret plan, to the king, to a public punishment, and then to a written record.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How does the message move through the story? Think about who speaks, and who listens? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:19—23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The young women who gather
- King Ahasuerus, who people also know as King Xerxes
- Mordecai
- Queen Esther
- The two eunuchs, Bigthana and Teresh
- And the king's servants

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Mordecai sits at the king's gate. Esther keeps her identity secret and obeys Mordecai.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Esther, "What are you feeling or thinking?"The person might answer things like:

- I will obey Mordecai; or
- I must keep this secret; or
- I trust Mordecai. Mordecai is like a father to me.

Continue the drama.

Two men become angry and make a plan to harm the king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry with the king; or
- I think we should act against the king; or
- Let us make a secret plan.

Continue the drama.

Mordecai learns about the plan.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Mordecai, "What are you feeling or thinking?"The person might answer things like:

- I want to protect Esther. If the king dies, bad things could also happen to Esther; or
- This is very serious and I must act on this news; or
- I must tell someone.

Continue the drama.

Mordecai tells Esther, and Esther tells the king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Esther, "What are you feeling or thinking?"The person might answer things like:

- I must now tell the king; or
- This is important news; or
- I want the king to like Mordecai, so I will tell the king that Mordecai found this out.

Continue the drama.

The king hears the report and investigates.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king, "What are you feeling or thinking?"The person might answer things like:

- I must know if this is true; or
- I must protect my life; or
- I will act quickly if this is true.

Continue the drama.

The king orders that the men die, and the servants lift the bodies up high.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the servants, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I must obey the king; or
- I feel shocked that these men planned to harm the king in this way; or
- People must see this; or
- This will warn others.

Esther 2:19–23

Continue the drama.

Servants write the event in the book of the history of the king, while the king is there.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing a servant, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer things like:

- I must write this down; or
- This is important; or
- The king must remember this.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Esther 2:19—23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.—

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this part of the story, the king’s servants gather the young women again. These young women are **virgins**. A virgin is a young woman who has not had sexual relations with a man. These women live under the care of the king’s servants. Use the same word or phrase for virgin as you used earlier in this book.

Mordecai sits at the king’s gate. A king’s gate is an important place at the entrance to the palace. People pass through this place each day. Like a city gate, people meet and deal with important matters at a king’s gate. In this story, Mordecai sits at the king’s gate, where Mordecai can hear what happens. Use the same word or phrase for **king** as you used in previous passages, and for more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **king’s gate**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In this story, Esther does not tell people about Esther’s **people** or Esther’s **family**. Use the same words or phrases for people and family as you used in Esther 2:10.

Two men, who are probably **eunuchs**, serve the king and guard the entrance to the palace. These men are trusted **officials** who work very close to the king. These officials guard the king and control who can enter. Many Bible translations use the word for officials for these two men**,** although these men are probably eunuchs. You may use either the word for officials or the word for eunuchs in your translation. If you use either of those words, use the same word for official or eunuch as you have used in previous passages.

The two men stand at the threshold of the king’s house. A threshold is the entrance to a building. A threshold is the place people step over when they enter through a door into a building. In this story, the men guard the entrance where people pass into the king’s house.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **threshold**. Think about the place people step over when they enter a house or building. Pause this audio here.

These two men become angry with the king. The men make a secret plan to harm the king. This is a plot. A plot means people agree in secret to hurt or kill someone. These people do not speak about this plan in public.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for a **plot** or secret plan. Pause this audio here. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Mordecai hears about this plan. Mordecai tells **Queen** Esther. Use the same word or phrase for queen that you have used previously, and refer to queen in the Master Glossary for more information.

Esther tells the king and says that Mordecai gave this report. The king’s servants check what Mordecai said. The servants find that this information is true. Then the king orders that the two men die. The servants place the bodies on a tall wooden pole and lift the bodies up high so people can see them. Sometimes people call this pole a “gallows.” It is a tall piece of wood. People put a body on this pole, sometimes on a sharp point, or hang

the body on it and lift it up high. People can see the body from far away. This shows shame and warns others not to make a plan against the king.

Stop here and look at a picture of a gallows, or pole, as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for pole, or **gallows**. Make sure the word clearly shows what happens. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

After this, the king's servants write down what happened. The servants write this in a book of the history of the king. This is a place where servants record important events so the king can remember later and act. In this story, the servants write down what Mordecai did in this book. People probably wrote this record of events on a scroll.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a scroll. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **scroll.** Think about how people in your culture keep written records. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. For more information on scroll, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Esther 2:19–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.0 MB)
- Setting the Stage (4.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Esther 3:1–6

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Esther 3:1—6 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:1—6 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:1—6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous part of the story, Mordecai heard about a plan that two men had made to kill the king. Mordecai told Esther about the plan, and Esther told the king. The king investigated and found that what Mordecai said was true. Then the king punished the two men and recorded this event in the book of the history of the king.

Some time after this, the king honors a man named Haman. Haman is the son of Hammedatha the Agagite. The king shows that Haman is very important. The king commands all the king's servants at the gate to bow down and show honor to Haman. By this command, the king shows that everyone must agree that Haman is an important man.

Stop here and discuss as a group: We do not know why the king gives Haman so much honor. In your community, why would you give someone this much honor? Pause this audio here.

The servants obey the king. When Haman passes by, the servants bow down low in front of Haman. This shows great honor and respect. In that culture, when people bowed like this, it showed that one person was much higher than another. It can also seem like the people treat Haman like a god. But Mordecai does not bow down or give this honor to Haman. Mordecai chooses not to obey the king's command.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of people bowing down before a ruler. Notice how low the people bow and how the people show honor. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In this story, the king commands people to bow down to Haman to show honor. In your culture, how do people show respect to a leader or an important person? Pause this audio here.

The king's servants at the gate see that Mordecai does not bow down. These servants speak to Mordecai every day. These servants ask Mordecai why Mordecai does not obey the king's command.

But Mordecai does not change his actions. Mordecai tells the servants that Mordecai is a Jew. The Jews are the people group that Mordecai comes from. You will remember that the Jews come from the kingdom of Judah, which was the southern kingdom of Israel, after Israel divided into two kingdoms many years before this story happened. Later, people called all the people who were from the kingdom of Israel, "Jews." The Jewish people follow the God of Israel. Many of these Jews now live in different places in the king's kingdom, not in their own land, the land of Israel.

The storyteller does not say clearly why Mordecai does not bow down. There may be two reasons. The people bow very low to Haman, almost like people worship a god. Mordecai may not do this because Mordecai follows Israel's God. Also, Haman is from a people group that has been enemies with all the people from Israel for many years. Long ago, the Agagites attacked the Israelites when the Israelites were weak. You can find this whole

story in Exodus 17:8–16, where the storyteller calls them the Amalekites. Because of this, there has been trouble between these two people groups for a long time.

The servants then tell Haman about Mordecai. The servants want to see if Mordecai will continue to refuse to bow down. When Haman sees that Mordecai does not bow down or show honor, Haman becomes very angry. Haman learns that Mordecai is a Jew. So Haman does not want to punish only Mordecai. Haman makes a plan to destroy all the Jews in all the kingdom of King Xerxes. Many people may die because of this plan. We already know Haman is from a people group that has been against the Jews for many years, so this may help explain why Haman becomes so angry.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the Persian Kingdom at the time of King Xerxes that shows how large the kingdom is. Notice how big the land is. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Haman becomes very angry with Mordecai and then makes a plan to harm many people. In your culture, what can happen when one person becomes very angry with another person? Pause this audio here.

This part of the story shows that Haman gains great power, and the king commands people to honor the king. Mordecai refuses to obey this command. This causes a problem between Haman and Mordecai. Haman becomes more and more angry, and Haman becomes a danger not only to Mordecai but to all the Jews. Many people may die because of this plan.

In the next part of the story, Haman will make a plan and set a time to carry out this plan against the Jews.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:1—6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: The king honors Haman and gives him a very important place in the palace. Haman is in authority above all the king's other officials.

In the second scene: The king commands all the king's servants at the gate to bow down low and show honor to Haman. The servants bow down. But Mordecai does not bow down. Mordecai does not show honor to Haman.

In the third scene: The king's servants ask Mordecai why he does not obey the king's command. The servants ask Mordecai again and again each day. Mordecai does not change his behavior. Mordecai tells the servants that Mordecai is a Jew.

In the fourth scene: The servants go to Haman and tell him what Mordecai is doing. Haman sees that Mordecai does not bow down. Haman becomes very angry. Haman makes a plan to destroy all the Jews, Mordecai's whole people group, in all the kingdom.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, whom people also call King Xerxes
- Haman
- Mordecai
- And the king's officials, or servants, at the gate

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The story begins with the words "after these events." The storyteller wants to show that this part of the story happens after the earlier events.

In the first scene, the storyteller says the king sets Haman's seat above the other governors, or high officials. This special language does not mean that Haman moves to a higher chair in the room. People use the word "seat" to speak about a place of honor and authority. When a person has a high seat, that person has a high position.

So the storyteller shows that Haman has a place of great honor and authority in the kingdom. Haman is second only to the king.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the king giving Haman a seat of honor higher than the other officials. Think about how people in your language speak about a person who has a higher position than others. Do you use a word like “seat,” or do you say “high position” or something else? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller says that the king gives a command to the officials, or servants. This helps us to understand why the officials bow down. All the officials obey this command, but Mordecai does not obey. Mordecai does not bow down. One man acts in a different way from everyone else. This shows a strong contrast. All the others bow down, but one man does not.

When the king’s officials, or servants, bow down to Haman, the servants lower their bodies to the ground. The servants bend low, or kneel, and put their faces toward the ground before Haman. This is how people show great honor. Sometimes people bow like this to a king. But the words here can also show something stronger. This kind of bowing can be like the way people bow to a god. It can show deep honor, almost like worship.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe this action. How do people in your language speak about bowing low before a person? Also, talk about how you will show the strength of this action. Does your language have a way to show bowing as people do before a god? Or will you say “bow very low” or “bow to the ground”? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about what happens when one person does not follow what everyone else is doing. As you translate this part, how will you show clearly that Mordecai acts very differently from all the other servants? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the officials speak to Mordecai again and again. The officials ask the same question each day. The storyteller uses the phrase “day after day.” This shows that the officials keep asking Mordecai and do not stop. But Mordecai does not change his actions. Mordecai tells the officials that Mordecai is a Jew.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out the conversation between the officials and Mordecai. Show how the officials ask again and again, and how Mordecai responds. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, the officials take the message to Haman. The message moves from Mordecai to the officials, and from the officials to Haman. Haman hears what Mordecai does, and Haman becomes very angry. The storyteller says that Haman scorns the idea of killing only Mordecai. This means Haman thinks it is not enough to kill just one man. The storyteller also says that Haman wants to “lay hands on” the Jews. This is special language. When someone lays hands on a person, it means that person wants to attack, harm, or kill that person. So the storyteller shows that Haman plans to harm not only Mordecai, but all the Jewish people.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate this part. How will you show that Haman thinks killing one man is not enough? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you translate “lay hands on” in a way that people understand that Haman wants to harm the Jews? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller shows that when Haman sees Mordecai not bowing, Haman becomes very angry. Haman is full of strong anger. This is not small anger. This is deep and powerful anger inside Haman. This kind of anger can cause a person to act quickly and without care.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the idea of this strong anger. What words do people in your language use for very strong anger? How will you show that this anger is stronger than normal anger and fills the whole person? Pause this audio here.

So first, Haman hears what Mordecai is doing. Then Haman becomes very angry. Haman is full of strong anger. Then Haman makes a plan. The storyteller shows each step clearly.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How does the message move in this part of the story? Who speaks, and who listens? Pause this audio here.

Think about how the storyteller moves the entire story from one part to the next. First, the king gives honor and power to Haman. Then the king gives a command, and most people obey. One man does not obey. Then people

ask questions and pass on the message. At the end, Haman becomes angry and makes a plan that will affect many people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How does a small action in this story lead to a much bigger problem? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:1—6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, whom people also call King Xerxes
- Haman
- Mordecai
- And the king's officials, or servants, at the gate

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The king honors Haman and gives him a high place.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Haman, "What are you feeling or thinking?"The person might answer things like:

- I feel proud; or
- I am now very important; or
- People must respect me.

Continue the drama.

The officials, or servants, bow down to Haman, but Mordecai does not bow down.Mordecai tells the servants that Mordecai is a Jew.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Mordecai, "What are you feeling or thinking?"The person might answer things like:

- I am happy to be a Jew; or
- I will not hide who my people are; or
- My people have had trouble with Haman's people for many years; or
- I love the God of Israel, and I will not act in a way that dishonors God.

Continue the drama.

The servants go to Haman and tell Haman what Mordecai is doing.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the servants, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We are shocked! We must tell Haman about this; or
- Mordecai is wrong. Mordecai is not showing respect; or
- Let us go and report this quickly.

Continue the drama.

Haman sees that Mordecai does not bow down, and Haman becomes very angry.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Haman, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer things like:

- I feel very angry; or
- How dare Mordecai refuse to show me respect? or
- I will act against Mordecai and all his people.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:1—6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The storyteller introduces Haman and calls Haman an Agagite. This name links Haman to a people group called the Amalekites that fought against the Jews long ago. There has been trouble between these people groups for many generations. This helps us understand why there is strong anger in this story.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Agagite**. You may choose to keep the name or to use a phrase that shows that Agag was a king whom the Israelites killed after they defeated Agag’s people. Pause this audio here.

After this, the storyteller shows that the **king** promotes Haman. This means the king gives Haman a more important position in the palace than before. The king puts Haman above other **governors,** or **high officials.** Haman now has more authority and more power in the kingdom. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages, and for more information, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for governors, or high officials, as you [used for the governors, or high government officials, in each province.]{.mark}

The **officials**, or **servants**, at the **king’s gate** bow down before Haman. Use the same word for the king’s gate as you have used previously. Sometimes people use the word servants for these officials. If you use the word servants for these officials, refer to servant in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for servants, or officials, as you have used in previous passages.

To bow down means to bend low in front of someone to show honor. In that culture, when people bow like this, it shows that one person is much higher than another. When people bow, it can also seem like people treat that person like a god.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **bow down**. Make sure the word shows a strong action of honor. Look up **bow** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In this story, people lower their bodies in front of that person to show that they honor the person and think the person is very important. This action shows respect and that the person has a higher place.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate **show great honor.** Pause this audio here.

But Mordecai does not bow down. The storyteller says that Mordecai had told the people that he was a **Jew**. A Jew is an Israelite from the kingdom of Judah, the southern kingdom of Israel. Later, people called everyone from Israel a “Jew.” Jews follow the God of Israel. Their people first lived in the land of Israel, but now many live in different places in the king’s kingdom. Use the same word or phrase for Jew as you have used in previous passages. For more information, refer to Jew in the Master Glossary.

The servants ask Mordecai why he disobeys the king's **command**. A command is when a ruler tells people what they must do. Use the same word or phrase for command as you used in previous passages.

Haman tries to find a way to destroy all the Jews throughout the **kingdom** of Xerxes. Use the same word or phrase for kingdom that you have used previously, and refer to kingdom in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Esther 3:1–6

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.0 MB)
- Setting the Stage (3.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Esther 3:7–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Esther 3:7–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:7–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.

5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:7—15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous part of this story, Haman became very angry with Mordecai because Mordecai did not bow down to Haman. Haman does not want to punish only Mordecai. Haman wants to punish all the Jewish people. So Haman makes a plan to destroy all the Jews in the whole kingdom of King Xerxes. Many people may die because of this plan.

In this part of the story, it is the first month of the year, which people call Nisan. This month is around March in our time. Esther has now been queen for about four years. Haman begins to prepare his plan. Haman casts lots. This means Haman uses small objects, like stones or pieces of wood, to choose a time. People usually throw these objects onto the ground. The way the objects fall on the ground shows people which time to choose. People in that culture believed that this would help people choose the right or best day to do something. Haman wants to choose the best time to destroy the Jews. The lot falls on the 12th month of the year, which people call Adar. The chosen day is many months away. This gives Haman time to prepare Haman's plan.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of what lots might look like, such as stones or marked pieces of wood. Notice how people use these objects to make a choice. Pause this audio here.

After this, Haman goes to King Xerxes to speak to the king about the Jews. Haman says that there is a group of people who live in many places all across the whole kingdom. Haman says that these people have different laws from other people. Haman says that these people do not obey the king's laws. Haman does not explain what the people disobeyed. Haman speaks in a way that sounds true, but Haman also hides the truth. Haman says some things that are true and some things that are not true. Haman speaks about a group of people but does not name the people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Why might a person try to persuade a leader to do something and hide the truth from the leader? Pause this audio here.

Haman speaks in a way that makes these people sound like a problem and a danger to the king. Haman tells the king that it is not good for the king to let these people stay. Haman does not say the name of this people group. Haman does not tell the king that these people are the Jews. The king probably does not know who Haman wants to destroy.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when a person mixed truth with lies to persuade others. What did the person say? What happened after that? Pause this audio here.

Haman then offers money to the king. Haman says that he will give a very large amount of silver if the king agrees with Haman's plan. At that time, people used silver as money. People gave silver to buy things or to pay someone. Haman uses this money to persuade the king and gain the king's agreement. The king then takes off his special signet ring that the king uses to show authority and gives it to Haman. With this ring, Haman can give commands in the king's name. People use this ring to press into soft wax to seal a message or command. This mark shows that the king himself approves the message or command.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a signet ring. Pause this audio here.

The king tells Haman to keep the money and to do whatever Haman thinks is best with the people. The king does not ask questions or check if this plan is good. The king does not even understand the full plan, but the king still gives Haman full authority.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when a leader did not ask questions or check the truth before making a decision. What happened? Pause this audio here.

Then the king's scribes write down Haman's command. This happens on the 13th day of the first month. This happens at the time every year when the Jews remember how God saved the Jews in the past. This special time is called Passover. At this same time, Haman continues his plan to destroy the Jewish people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What special days in the year do your people have to remember something good from the past? What would people feel if a new danger came at that same time of the year? Pause this audio here.

The scribes write letters to all the king's officials in every part of the kingdom. The scribes write in the language of each people group so that everyone can understand. The letters give a command to destroy, kill, and completely remove all the Jews. This command is not small or local. This command is a planned action across the whole kingdom at the same time. This command is for all the Jews, in every place. This includes young people, old people, women, and children. The letters set a day for this to happen. This day is the 13th day of the 12th month, the month of Adar. The letters also say that people can take the Jews' things for themselves. Messengers take these letters to all parts of the kingdom. The king's command goes out quickly. The king's messengers also announced the message in the city of Susa, where the king lives. Once the king has written and sealed this command, no one can easily change the command.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the Persian Kingdom. Notice how large the kingdom is and how many places these messages must go to. Pause this audio here.

After this, the king and Haman sit down to drink wine. The king and Haman act as if nothing is wrong. But the people in the city feel confused and troubled. The people do not understand why the king has given this command.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people feel when a ruler makes a command that seems unfair or hard to understand? Can you tell a story of a time when this happened? Pause this audio here.

This part of the story shows how Haman sets a time and gains the king's authority to carry out Haman's plan. The king does not think carefully, but just agrees to the plan. The servants send out a command across the whole kingdom to destroy the Jews. Many people may die because of this plan. The people in the city of Susa feel troubled. One man, Haman, now has the power to control what happens, and Haman uses this power for evil.

In the next part of the story, Mordecai will hear about this command and will respond.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:7–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: Haman wants to choose the best time to carry out Haman's plan. Haman casts lots to choose the day. The lot falls on a day many months later. Haman now has time to prepare Haman's plan.

In the second scene: Haman goes to King Xerxes. Haman speaks about a group of people who live across the kingdom. Haman does not say this people group's name. Haman says these people are different and do not obey the king's laws. Haman hides the truth and makes these people sound like a problem. Haman offers money to persuade the king and to get the king's agreement.

In the third scene: The king does not ask questions or check the truth. The king takes his signet ring and gives it to Haman. This means that Haman can act in the king's name. The king tells Haman to do what seems good to Haman.

In the fourth scene: The king's scribes write down the command in the king's name and seal it with the king's ring. This makes the command final.

In the fifth scene: Messengers take the command to every part of the kingdom. The king's command tells people to destroy all the Jews—young and old Jews, men, women, and children—on one day. The command says that people can also take the Jews' property.

In the sixth scene: The king and Haman sit down to drink wine. The king and Haman act as if nothing is wrong. But the people in the city of Susa feel confused and troubled.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, whom people also know as King Xerxes
- Haman
- The king's scribes and the king's satraps, governors, and high provincial officials
- The messengers
- The people in the city of Susa
- And the Jewish people

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This part of the story happens in King Xerxes' 12th year. Esther has been queen for about four years. The storyteller tells us the time at the start of this passage. This helps us know when these events happen. The story begins with the king in the palace. Then the command goes out across the whole kingdom.

In the first scene, Haman asks another person to throw small objects onto the ground to choose a time. The person throws these objects, and the objects fall in a certain way on the ground. The way the objects fall shows which month and day to choose. The objects show Haman to choose a time far in the future. This shows that Haman plans carefully.

In the second scene, Haman speaks in a way that sounds true, but Haman really hides the truth. Haman says that these people live in every part of the kingdom. Haman says that these people keep themselves separate from other people. Haman explains this by saying that these people's customs are different and that they do not obey the king's commands. Haman does not say who these people are.

Haman also uses money to persuade the king. Haman offers 10,000 talents of silver. One talent is about 30 to 34 kilograms of silver, so 10,000 talents is about 340,000 kilograms of silver! Many people would need many years to earn this much.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about these talents of silver? Will you talk about the weight of the talents in kilos? Pause this audio here?

In the third scene, the king gives his authority to Haman. The king does not check the truth or ask questions. Haman now has great power. The storyteller says Haman's full name again—Haman, son of Hammedatha—and says that Haman is an Agagite. This reminds the listeners that Haman is an enemy of the Jews.

In the fourth and fifth scenes, the storyteller shows each step in order. First the king gives the command. Haman calls the scribes and tells the scribes what to write. The scribes write the message to the satraps, who are the highest government leaders over several provinces, and to the governors of the provinces, and to the officials who help the governors and lead groups of people in the provinces. The scribes write the message on scrolls in every language of the kingdom so that all people can understand the message. The message says that people must destroy the Jews and take their property. Then the messengers carry the scrolls quickly to all parts of the kingdom. The messengers hurry and take the message everywhere. This command puts many people in danger.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Act out how the message moves from one person to another. Show how the message spreads across the kingdom quickly. Pause this audio here.

In the sixth scene, the storyteller shows a strong contrast. The king and Haman sit down together, drink wine together, and act as if nothing is wrong, but the people of the city feel troubled and confused.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do the people feel in this scene? Why do the people feel this way? Pause this audio here.

Think about how the story moves from one part to the next. Show who has authority at each step. Show who speaks, who writes, and who carries the message. First, Haman chooses a time. Then Haman speaks to the king. Then the king gives authority to Haman. Then the scribes write the command, and the messengers send the command out. At the end, people across the whole kingdom hear this command and are affected by it.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How does one man's plan grow and affect many people in this story? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:7—15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahasuerus, whom people also know as King Xerxes
- Haman
- The king's scribes and the king's satraps, governors, and high provincial officials
- The messengers
- The people in the city of Susa
- And the Jewish people

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Someone casts lots for Haman to choose a time to kill all the Jews.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Haman, "What are you feeling or thinking?"The person might answer things like:

- I want to choose the very best time; or
- I want my plan to succeed; or
- I will wait for the right day.

Continue the drama.

Haman speaks to the king about a certain group of people who are dangerous to the king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Haman, "What are you feeling or thinking?"The person might answer things like:

- I will not tell the king who these people are; or
- I will try to speak in a way that convinces the king; or
- I really want the king to agree with me.

Continue the drama.

Haman offers money to the king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Haman, "What are you feeling or thinking?"The person might answer things like:

- I will use money to persuade the king; or
- I think that the king will agree to my plan if I offer this money; or
- This plan must go forward.

Continue the drama.

The king gives his signet ring to Haman.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer things like:

- I trust Haman; or
- I will let Haman deal with this; or
- This does not seem important to me.

Continue the drama.

Haman dictates the message to the scribes.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Haman, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer things like:

- I will make this command strong so no one will question it; or
- I will use the king’s authority to carry out my plan; or
- I must make sure this message reaches every place quickly.

Continue the drama.

The people in the city hear the command.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the people, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- This is very troubling; or
- Why has the king given this terrible command? or
- This does not seem right or fair.

Continue the drama.

The king and Haman sit and drink together.

Ask the person playing the king, “What are you feeling or thinking?”The person might answer things like:

- I feel calm; or
- This matter is finished; or
- I trust Haman to deal with this.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Esther 3:7—15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Haman wants to choose a day to carry out Haman’s plan. Haman asks someone to cast lots, that is, to throw small objects, like stones or pieces of wood, onto the ground. The way the objects fall shows which day to choose. People in that culture believe this shows the right or best day to act. The lot falls on a day far in the future.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **throwing lots**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says this story happens in the 12th year of **King** Xerxes, in the month of Nisan, which is the first month of the year. This month comes around March or April in a modern calendar. The chosen day is in the month of Adar, which is the 12th month of the year. This month comes around February or March. This means many

months pass between these two times. Haman plans far ahead to destroy the Jewish people. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used previously, and refer to king in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Nisan** and **Adar**. You can use the modern names if you wish, or, if you have already translated the names of these months in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Haman goes to the king and speaks about a group of people who live all over the **kingdom**. These people are the **Jews**, who follow the God of Israel. Haman does not say the people's name. Haman speaks about these people as if they were just a group of people. Use the same words or phrases for Jews and kingdom as you used in previous passages. Look up Jews and kingdom in the Master Glossary for more information.

Haman says that these people have different **laws** or customs, that is, the rules the people follow and the way they live. Haman says that these people do not follow the king's commands. Haman uses this to make the Jews sound like a problem to the king. Use the same word or phrase for Persian laws as you have used in previous passages.

Then Haman offers the king a very large amount of silver, which is a valuable metal that people use as money. Haman offers the king 10,000 talents of silver. One talent is about 30 to 34 kilograms of silver, so 10,000 talents is about 340,000 kilograms of silver!

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **silver**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture that shows a very large amount of silver, such as many bags or piles of silver stacked together. Notice how much space it takes and how heavy it would be. This helps us understand that Haman offers a huge amount of money. Pause this audio here.

A talent is a large unit that people used to measure silver or gold. One talent is a very heavy amount of metal. In this story, Haman offers many talents of silver to the king. This shows that Haman offers a very large amount of money.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **talent**. Look up talent in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Haman says the silver will go into the king's treasuries, which are places where a king or ruler keeps money and valuable things. Workers bring money into the treasury, and the king uses the money to pay for the kingdom's needs.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **treasuries**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king agrees and gives Haman the king's signet ring. This is a special ring that shows the king's authority. A person can press this ring into soft wax on a message. The mark shows that the king approves the message. When the king gives this ring to Haman, Haman can act with the king's authority.

Stop here and look at a picture of a signet ring as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **signet ring**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Haman calls the scribes, who are people who write things down for the king and for officials. Scribes write letters, records, and commands. Haman tells the scribes what to write, and the scribes write down Haman's words. The scribes write the king's command, that is, an order that people must obey. In this story, the scribes write the king's command so messengers can send the command out to the whole kingdom.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **scribe**. These scribes do not write the laws of Yahweh, so you may need to use a different word than you have used in other books of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

A command, or **decree**, is an order from a ruler. People must obey the decree. In this story, the king gives a command that people must follow. Use the same word or phrase for decree as you used in previous passages.

The scribes write this command as a proclamation, which means the scribes prepare the message so that officials can read the message out loud in public places for many people to hear. This means that everyone knows what the ruler has commanded.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **proclamation**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The scribes write this message in every **language**, or **tongue**, that people speak in the Persian Kingdom. Each place receives the message in its own language and in its own way of writing. A way of writing means the form or system people use to write their words. Use the same word or phrase for language and script, or way of writing, that you used in Esther 1:22. For more information about language, refer to tongues in the Master Glossary.

The scribes write the message to the satraps, who are the highest government leaders over several provinces, and to the governors of the provinces, and to the officials who help the governors and lead groups of people in the provinces.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **satraps**, **governors**, and **officials** who help the governors lead groups of people. The word for satraps is a special Persian word for the highest government officials. Pause this audio here.

The scribes finish writing the message, and the scribes seal the message. This means the scribes mark the message in a way that shows the message is official. The scribes use the king's ring to press a mark into wax on the message. This mark shows that the message truly comes from the king.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **seal**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king sends out messengers. Messengers are people who carry messages from one place to another. In this story, the messengers carry the king's command on small **scrolls** to all parts of the kingdom. The messengers travel long distances, often on roads, across the Persian Kingdom. Messengers may ride horses or move from one place to another quickly so that a message reaches many people. Use the same word or phrase for scroll as you have used in previous passages, and refer to scroll in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for these kinds of **messengers**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king's command says that people must destroy, kill, and annihilate the Jews. These are three similar words that mean the people must kill the Jews and remove the Jews completely so that no one remains alive.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **destroy**, **kill**, and **annihilate**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king's command also says that people can plunder the Jews. This means that people can take what belongs to the Jews. After people kill the Jews, people can go into the Jews' homes and take everything of value, such as money, animals, or goods.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **plunder**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

The messengers send out the message in the **stronghold** of Susa. Use the same word or phrase for stronghold as you have used in previous passages. Refer to stronghold in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Esther 3:7–15

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (7.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)